

Chapter Seven

OTHELLO AND HAMLET: SPYING, DISCOVERY, SECRET FAULTS

nor must it go for nothing that by the distant voyages and travels which
have become frequent in our times many things in nature have been *laid*
open and discovered

Francis Bacon

a most diligent searcher of hidden secrets . . .

William Camden, on Francis Walsingham

The lap or privy dilated or laide open . . .

Helkiah Crooke

At the beginning of *Othello's* pivotal temptation scene, Iago begins to set Othello "on the rack," through pauses, single words, and phrases that seem to suggest something secret or withheld, a withholding that fills the Moor with the desire to know more:

I heard thee say even now, thou lik'st not that,
When Cassio left my wife. What didst not like?
. . . If thou dost love me,
Show me thy thought.

(III.iii.109–16)¹

In the lines that follow in the Folio (and Q2, Q3) version of this scene, Iago's stops and starts are called "close dilations, working from the heart" (123). The appearance of these "close dilations" in all of the texts of the play but one might justify pausing over the implications of this enigmatic phrase, if only at first because of the length and puzzlement of the commentary it has caused.

In the glosses the phrase has been given from eighteenth-century editors forward, several senses of *dilation* have been suggested: that "dilations anciently signified delays" (Steevens)—an overtone significant in a play where Iago says of his own stage managing, "we work by wit, and not by witchcraft, / And wit depends on *dilatory* time" (II.iii.372–73)—and that *dilate* in early modern English meant simply to amplify or "speak at large."² There is, however, one maverick voice in this tradition of commentary: that of Samuel Johnson, who read the Folio's "close dilations"

as if it meant "close *delations*" or "occult and secret *accusations*." Though clearly fascinating to more than one subsequent commentator, Johnson's reading has also been rejected more than once on the grounds that, as Arden editor M. R. Ridley put it, "there is no evidence of the use of the word in this, its Latin, sense" in Shakespeare's day. Ridley himself, puzzling over the Folio phrase and remarking that, since "it can hardly have been due to a mere blunder," whoever put it there must have "meant something by it," finally confesses that he has "very little idea what that was" and concludes by choosing instead the only other possible text (the "close denotements" of Q1) on the grounds (following Malone) that to this more neutral phrase at least "no reasonable objection can be made."³

This objection to Dr. Johnson's "delations" or "secret accusations" rests, then, on the assumption that there is no evidence of the use of *dilations* or *delations* in this sense in the period of the play. Yet, in fact, such instances abound, not just in minor texts but in the works of Ben Jonson among more major writers. The *OED* (under *delate* as "to accuse, bring a charge against, impeach . . . inform against") cites an example from 1536 of a person "dilatit of adultery"—a phrase highly resonant for *Othello*. Under the related sense of "to report, inform of (an offence, crime, fault)," it cites several contemporary instances, including one from Jonson's *Volpone* ("They may delate / My slacknesse to my patron"). And under *delation* as "an accusing or bringing a charge against, *esp.* on the part of an informer," it gives as an example the Folio's "close dilations" from the temptation scene, noting that *delation* was a variant of *dilation* (just as *dilate* was a variant of *delate*).⁴ In early modern English, then, *dilate* and *delate* were alternative spellings for a range of meanings, including not just amplifying or opening but reporting, delaying, and accusing—all resonances that *dilation* variously takes on within *Othello* itself. The terms appear, indeed, to be so closely linked as to be available for exploitation as homophonic doubles, as when Bishop Hall condemns "dilators of errors" as "delators of your brethren." The link between judicial *delation* and rhetorical or narrative *dilation* is exploited in Shakespeare from as early as the opening of *Love's Labor's Lost*.⁵ The reasons given for excluding the resonance of "secret accusations" from the "close dilations" of the Folio and other texts are thus indefensible if they assume the nonexistence of *dilation* (or its alternate, *delation*) in the sense of accusation in Shakespeare's day, since even the most cursory search of early modern texts yields an embarrassing abundance of uses of the term in exactly this judicial sense, as well as instances of a paronomastic crossing of the two—

delation and dilation, that which accuses and that which opens and amplifies.

I want, therefore, to begin from these controversial "close dilations"—from, in other words, what might again seem to be only a marginal or minor textual matter—in order to consider in a different context in this final chapter the implications of reading Shakespeare and the texts of early modern culture with an awareness of the historical resonance of their terms. To do this, I propose to set beside two major Shakespearean plays—first *Othello* and then, in diptych fashion, *Hamlet*—a series of contemporary contexts in which the language of spying, discovery, or bringing before the eye (prominent in both plays) appears across a broad range of discourses: first, the function of the delator or informer as secret accuser, part of the sixteenth-century development of a nascent secret service and the apparatus of judicial discovery; secondly, the anatomical context of uncovering, dilating, or opening the secret or "privy" place of woman, the discourse of anatomy that brings another hidden, close, or secret "fault" to light; thirdly, early modern European fascination both with monster literature and with narratives of the "discovery" of previously hidden worlds; and finally, the category of the monstrous more generally, including the fault (as well as open secret) of unsanctioned homoerotic couplings. Once again, the methodological premise is that by attending to the historical dimensions of something like what Raymond Williams called "key words," across a broad range of contemporary contexts and discourses, we can become better readers and editors of even the best known of Shakespeare plays; and that, conversely, by bringing the kind of close reading usually associated with literary texts to bear on such texts and discourses, we can become more acute readers of early modern culture.



Let us return, then, to *Othello* and the "close dilations" of the temptation scene. It is here that Iago, the figure who will become "virtually an archetype of the informer" in this play,⁶ introduces the hints and inferences that set Othello "on the rack," creating a sense of something needing to be brought forth to "show":

OTHELLO: Think, my lord? By heaven, thou echo'st me,
 As if there were some *monster* in thy thought
Too hideous to be shown. Thou dost mean something.
 I heard thee say even now, thou lik'st not that,

When Cassio left my wife. What didst not like?
 And when I told thee he was of my counsel
 In my whole course of wooing, thou criest, "Indeed!"
 And didst *contract and purse* thy brow together,
 As if thou then hadst *shut up* in thy brain
 Some horrible conceit. If thou dost love me,
 Show me thy thought.

(III.iii.106–16)

These powerful lines—forging their punning links between *monster* and *show*, *hideous* and *hid*—are the ones that lead first to Othello's suspicion of "close dilations, working from the heart" (123) and then to hunger for information from one he assumes "sees and knows more, much more, than he unfolds" (243).⁷ Beyond their immediate resonance in the temptation scene, they also forge links (through "contract and purse," "shut up," and "show") with the opening of the play or theatrical show, which begins with enigmatic reference to something not to be told ("Tush, never tell me!") and to a purse whose mouth can be opened or shut (1.i.1–3).

In the semantic field of early modern English, the *close* of these close dilations means secret or private—the opposite of what is displayed or shown—as in Claudius's "we have *closely* sent for Hamlet" (III.i.29) in a context that clearly means "privily" or "secretly."⁸ But it also manages to suggest the sense of something constricted or closed, a sense that echoes the scene in Act I where Othello narrates his response to Desdemona's entreaty that he might "all [his] pilgrimage dilate" (I.iii.153), opening to her "greedy ear" what had previously been known only in "parcels" or in part (149–55). "Close dilations" convey the sense of partial opening and partial glimpses of something closed or hid, just as the resonances of "accusations" in Johnson's "occult" or "secret" sense surround Iago with hints of the informer who works behind doors. Dilation as delation also carried with it the implications of a specifically *narrative* relation or report, just as dilation as *rhetorical* opening had to do with uncovering and bringing before the eye. Dilation in the sense of accusation was a charge made "privilie" or "secretlie," a *delator* a "privie" or "secret accuser" or bearer of report.⁹ The close dilations of the Folio's temptation scene, therefore, need not even be altered to the "close delations" of Johnson's emendation in order to convey an already overdetermined sense of secret accusations, the activity of an informer carried out privately, without the knowledge of others, which comes in *Othello* only after the damage of accusations made in secret has been done. To look closely at the close dilations of this

controversial text, then, is to discover the implications of dilation in the multiple senses of opening and informing, discovery and indictment, of bringing forth to show something privy or close; and its range of meaning is a reminder of the inseparability of rhetorical and judicial in early modern discourse, of opening a case and bringing a cause to light.

That the close dilations of the scene in which Desdemona's accuser begins the secret work of his informing should summon the more ominous judicial sense of "information" is far from surprising in a play where reminders of the judicial are so pervasive, both in the domestic sphere and in the affairs of state—from the Moor's summons to answer the charge of witchcraft before the Venetian senate in Act I to his invocation of a justifying cause ("It is the cause, it is the cause") as he himself prepares to be judge and executioner in the scene of Desdemona's death.¹⁰ But in order to convey a fuller sense of the historical myopia of excluding an informer's delations from the resonances of the close dilations of the Folio text, we also need to set the language of this passage and its informing beside the contemporary context and language of delation, spying, and privy intelligence.

Here there is a wealth of contemporary references to delators as secret or "privie" informers (those who inform *about* the secret and inform *in* secret) as part of the "floating population" of informers and spies in the years before more full-scale development of the police and policing apparatus of the state. Historians of early modern England speak of the dilations or delations (secret accusations) that were a crucial part of this new domestic apparatus of discovery, in the sense of bringing some hidden conspiracy, fault, or crime to light. G. R. Elton emphasizes the importance of "delations and informations" in the development of judicial discovery as early as Cromwell's regime.¹¹ Even more acutely in Elizabeth's reign, in the wake of the 1581 Act against Reconciliation with Rome and the papal bull *Regnans in excelsis* forbidding her subjects under pain of excommunication to obey "her orders, mandates and laws," the close dilations of Iago as accuser and informer have their counterpart in the multiplication of delators encouraged by the need to ferret out recusants and harborers of secret treason to the queen.¹² In the context of this paranoid atmosphere of spying and being spied upon, one text from the decade before *Hamlet* and *Othello* reports on the omnipresence of "secret spies" who "do insinuate themselves into our company and familiarity" with such pretense of "zeal, sincerity, and friendship" that they are able both to "inform" and "give intelligence" of the most "secret intents." Francis Walsingham—the secretary of state who so enlarged the Elizabethan network of intelli-

gence—was described in his obituary notice as “a most diligent searcher of hidden *secrets*.”¹³

The business of detection and informing, of espial and bringing “privie secretes” before the eye, was part of the obsession in early modern England with things done “privilie” or in secret, in the confessional, the “secret chamber” of the heart, or the “closet” of a monarch.¹⁴ And echoes of this network of informers, agents, and “intelligence” are everywhere in Shakespeare, from the “suborn’d informer” of Sonnet 125 to the “poursuivant” of *Richard III* (part of what Elton calls the “primitive police system” of sixteenth-century England), from the “smiling pick-thanks and base newsmongers” (1H4, I.ii.25) who bear against Hal what Holinshed termed “informations that *privilie* charged him with . . . demeanor unseemelie for a prince” to the “tales and informations” gathered by Cromwell in *Henry VIII* (V.ii.145) and the forms of intelligence and report we have already encountered in chapter 5. Especially resonant for *Othello* and the figure of “birdlime” applied to Iago (II.i.126) is the description of such “lynx-eyed” men as having the faculty of a “lime twig,” able to “catch” anything that comes close.¹⁵

Things done in secret that depended on intelligence or report—crimes, like adultery and witchcraft, beyond the access of ocular proof—are very much part of the atmosphere of espial and informing in the period before *Hamlet*, itself filled with attempts to uncover an “occulted guilt” (III.ii.80), and *Othello*, which introduces early on a bearer of reports who puts the Venetians in what is called “false gaze” (I.iii.19).¹⁶ But the contemporary world of informing and espials, of the “close” or secret both brought to light and judged, is also joined by other contemporary contexts resonant in different ways for these two plays, including the forms of espial concerned with a female close or “secrete” place and the simultaneously visual and sexualized language of a quasi-pornographic monster literature and Eurocentric narratives of other-world “discovery.” It is to these contexts, then, that we need to turn before returning to consider, in different ways, the language and plotting of these two plays.



Like the letter, o, small and wondrous narrow. . . Too
obscure to look upon.

Helkiah Crooke

In order to chart first the links between the judicial language of discovery—of delation or informing as the spying out of secrets—and contempo-

rary discourses that have to do with the discovery of a secret female place, we need to consider once more the close dilations of the temptation scene, this time not simply as secret accusations but in their other sense of "opening." To *dilate* in early modern usage came with a sense of widening, stretching, or enlarging something closed. Thus, as we have remarked, it could also convey the rhetorical sense of to "speak at large," expanding or discursively spreading out something originally smaller or more constricted.¹⁷ In the rhetorical and narrative sense introduced into the play in Othello's own reference to the request that he would "*all [his] pilgrimage dilate*" (I.iii.153), the link with dilation made rhetoric itself a form of opening, illustrated by the figure of the open palm in contrast to logic's closed fist. One of the most famous of early modern descriptions characterizes rhetorical dilation as an enlarging or unfolding through which the eye is enabled to see things previously "folded" or closed ("*open[ing] up those things which were included in a single word*"). To dilate, then, was directly related to a visual sense of opening up to show—"like displaying some object for sale first of all through a lattice or inside a wrapping, and then unwrapping it and opening it out and displaying it *more fully to the gaze*." Descriptions of such rhetorical opening manage to suggest an eroticized, voyeuristic or even prurient looking, not just a way to "spread abroad" something hidden or closed but a means through which "to open the bosom of nature and to *shew* her branches, to that end they may be *viewed and looked upon, discerned and known*."¹⁸

It is this dimension of dilation that enabled the easy movement between rhetorical and sexual opening, between the open palm of rhetoric and the open hand or palm taken (as in *Othello* or *The Winter's Tale*) as sign of the openness of a woman and her sexual appetite, a "frank" and "liberal" hand that argues a licentious or a "liberal heart" (*O*, III.iv.36–46).¹⁹ In Shakespeare, this link between opening a "matter" rhetorically "at large" and the sexual opening or enlarging of a woman is already familiar from the so-called Dark Lady sonnets of a "large" and "spacious" female "will" (Sonnet 135), a closed or "private" female place become the "wide world's *common* place" (137).²⁰ Concern that this secret or "privie" place might become instead a common place characterized in particular the anxieties of adultery, fear that a virgin, once opened, could not have her "opening" controlled. To open or dilate a virgin, the term used routinely in the period for such sexual opening, involved the threat of enlargement in every sense: the opening of a formerly closed and "privie" place that simultaneously opened up the possibility that a woman

might be at large in a more threatening way—that, as Othello puts it, “we can call these delicate creatures ours, / And not their appetites” (III.iii.269–70). “Close,” then, in the “close dilations” of the temptation scene, carries the implication of private and secret in a sexual sense, a hidden place that only through opening could be displayed or shown. This sense of close as secret or hid in relation to the sexual “privitie” of women informs contemporary discussions of this privy female place, as well as the language of spying, informing, or espial that includes fascination with a woman’s chamber or closet in *Othello* and *Hamlet*.

The language of the close or secret—of a hidden matter or matrix to be dilated, opened and displayed—pervades the literature on the “privities” of woman in contrast to the exteriorized sexual parts of man. Helkiah Crooke’s “Of the Lap or Privities” (“in Latine *pudendum muliebre*, that is, the womans modesty”) treats, for example, of “the outward privity or lap” of woman as a “cleft” that like a “doore” might be opened or shut—a sense of the close or closeted behind a door that pervades medical as well as popular references to this secret place. In ways highly suggestive when placed beside the familiar Shakespearean euphemism for the female sexual orifice, the *O* or “nothing” printed in early Shakespeare texts as a graphically smaller *o*, the orifice of the matrix or womb is described in this same medical text as “like the letter, o, small and wondrous narrow,” yet capable of being “*more open*” according to “the womans appetite.”²¹ Crooke’s and other discussions of this privy female place repeatedly treat of its capacity to dilate—first in the opening of a “closed” virginity (where it is rare that “the Membranes are dilated with little or no paine”) and thereafter both in childbirth and “in Copulation,” when the matrix or “mouth of the womb” is “*dilated with extreme pleasure* in intercourse.”²² The sexual dilation of a virgin, or more experienced woman, was thus in every sense an opening to increase, the enlarging of something close or closed whose opening was essential to fulfilling the command to increase and multiply. In ways resonant beside the “close dilations” of the temptation scene and its “contract and purse,” the image used repeatedly in contemporary discussions of this “privie” female place was of something “dilated and shut together like a purse,” a figure that appears in the work of physician Thomas Vicary (“open” or “shut together as a Purse mouth”), as in such popular texts as *De secretis mulierum*, or “On the Secrets of Women.”²³ The privity or lap itself was understood as something folded and hence needing to be unfolded in order to be available for show²⁴—a sense of unfolding exploited not only in Othello’s suspicion that his informer “Sees

and knows more, much more, than he *unfolds*" but in the obscene play on *lap* in *Hamlet*, as we shall see.

As with rhetorical dilation as an unwrapping or unfolding to the eye, the female lap or privy was thus something folded or closed as well as something secret or close. Here, in the impulse of anatomical discourse to open up to show, the links are even clearer between the language of the spy or informer exposing something secret to the eye and the discourses surrounding a woman's secret place, not only brought to light but indicted and judged. In his discussion "Of the Lap or Privities," Crooke not only speaks of the little *o* that is "more open or more contracted" according to the "womans appetite"; he also provides an anatomical diagram of this secret place in which "the cleft of the lap or privy" is described as "dilated or laide open" to the gazer's view (220). The dilating of a woman figures in these texts both sexually *and* visually, both as opening and as bringing a secret place before the eye.

This sense of dilated as visual opening is of course part of the ocular impulse of anatomy more generally—its preoccupation with what William Harvey called "ocular inspection," with what can or cannot be opened up to "shew," an impulse that has led recent commentators to align it with the specularity of theater. Like informing or espial, the vogue for anatomy in the early modern period involved a fascination with the ocular, with exposing what lay hid to the scrutiny of the gaze.²⁵ The impulse to open and expose as epistemological hunger to "see and know" is in the case of the "privitie" of woman, however, a much more complicated impulse, a desire both to see and not to see, to display to the eye and to discourage or refrain from looking. Crooke himself both calls attention to the diagram displaying "the lap or privy dilated or laide open" to the view and warns that this place is "*too obscoene to look upon*," a warning it shares with other descriptions of the occult or hidden parts of women. Beside the exposed anatomy of a man, its title page sets the more modestly opaque and closed body of a woman, covering her private parts.²⁶ Its text speaks particularly of the "o" or "fissure that admitteth the yard" as "a part thought too obscoene to look upon," adding that this is the reason, "sayth Pliny, that the carcasses of women do floate in the water with their faces downeward, contrary to mens which swimme upward; even Nature itself yeelding to modesty" (239)—a claim to which we will need to return in the case of the *O* of Ophelia and her more immodest drowning.

A sense of this secret female place as something too obscene for show recurs repeatedly in anatomical discourse.²⁷ The sense of a female privy

too obscene to be seen also lies behind the simultaneous warnings against and stimulation of the gaze in anatomical treatises aware of bringing before the eye what otherwise would be lapped, folded, secret, hid. Crooke warns in relation to the "obscoene parts" of woman that caution must be exercised in describing and hence displaying them vicariously to the eye: "We will first describe the parts of generation belonging to men, and then proceede to those of Women also: of which wee would advise no man to take further knowledge then shall serve for his good instruction" (199). A kindred sense of the pornographic dangers of opening and displaying close and secret female parts sounds through Eucharius Roesslin's *The Byrth of Mankinde* and its warning that some "wold have hadde this booke forbidden" because it "descried and set forth the secretes and privities of women" in ways that allowed "every boy and knave" to view them "openly."²⁸

Ambivalence, then, about opening up to "shew" this secret part produces what might be called the anatomical text's pornographic doubleness, its simultaneous opening up and denying to the eye. In this sense, exposures of a female lap or "privitie" are part of the more general hunger in the period for pornographic or quasi-pornographic display, not just in gynecological description or anatomical illustration but in the extraordinary popularity of a "monster" literature—the word itself (as in *Othello*) forging a link between showing or *demonstrating* and the monstrous previously unknown or hidden from vision.²⁹ Crooke's text both presents a female "lap" or privy "dilated or laide open" to the eye and warns its readers against the uses to which this dilation or unfolding might be put—in a way not unlike the pandering and pornographic doubleness of Iago's simultaneous invitation to and prohibition of the ocular.³⁰ In a metaphor that already linked the opening of a woman to the opening of a book, texts of anatomy that exposed such secrets encountered the problem of *publishing*, in the sense of making public, the double of the impulse to display (*displicare*, "unfold") that in the instance of opening a woman up to show risked turning a private into a common place.



These texts of anatomy, however, also have another telling dimension, one that combines the sexualized as well as visual language of the dilation of a hidden female place with another early modern context of the bringing to light of something hid. In his discussion of the "Lap or Privities" of women, Crooke treats of the "clitoris" or "woman's yard" as something

that lyeth *deeply hidden in the body*, and hence it is called *aestrum Veneris* & *dulcedo amoris*; for in it with the ligaments inserted into it is, the especiall seate of delight in their veneral imbracements, as *Columbus imagineth he first discovered*.

The Columbus cited here along with his claim to this "discovery" is not Christopher Columbus but Renaldus Columbus, the anatomist who in 1559 claimed to have brought this other previously unknown territory to light.³¹ Of the hidden or secret female part that this "Columbus imagineth he first discovered," however, Crooke also warns that

this part it is which those wicked women doe abuse called *Tribades* (often mentioned by many authours, and in some states worthily punished) to their mutuall and unnaturall lustes.

And in the margins of this warning about the female matrix, lap, or "privacy," Crooke cites Leo Africanus, the converted Moor whose *Geographical History of Africa*, produced in Arabic and Italian in 1526, had been widely translated and reprinted in Europe after its publication in Venice by Gian Battista Ramusio in 1550. Reference to Africanus's travel or discovery narrative also appears in an earlier, highly influential text of anatomy in the period, Ambroise Paré's *De l'anatomie de tout le corps humain* (1585), after being excised (following pressure from censors) from the more popular format of his *Des monstres et prodiges* (1573). The passage from Africanus cited in Paré (in the context of the monstrous both as the hidden from the view and as part of the description of the hidden or secret parts of women) also has to do with the particular hidden part that the anatomist Columbus claimed to have discovered, including the "monstrous" sexual practice of women abusing themselves with other women—a practice Paré pronounces "monstrous and difficult to believe" and then seeks to make credible by inclusion of a story from Africanus of the women of Barbary.³²

Paré's *On Monsters and Prodigies* was a popular and much-cited text, part of the burgeoning "monster" literature of the European sixteenth century and its vogue for quasi-pornographic display. The very popularity of such monster literature was a phenomenon parallel to the growing European appetite for travel narratives at the threshold of the early modern period—filled by texts like the repeatedly translated one of this converted Moor.³³ Janis Pallister, in her recent translation of Paré, notes the derivation of *monster* both from the root of warnings or signs (*monere* + *-strum*) and from a sense of bringing forth to show (*monstrare*). But what is being

warned about here—and then shown more graphically through illustration from Africanus's travel narrative—are not foreign monsters but civic and domestic ones, the practices of European women projected onto women of Barbary.³⁴



regions of the material globe . . . have been in our times laid widely open and revealed.

Francis Bacon, *The New Organon*

Africa, which for a thousand yeeres before had lien buried . . . is now plainly discovered and laid open to the view.

Jean Bodin, on Leo Africanus

A link is already forged, then, in these European treatises of anatomy—Paré's in French, Crooke's in English, and the Latin treatise of another Columbus—between the anatomist's opening and exposing to the eye the secrets or "privities" of women and the "discovery" or bringing to light of what were from a Eurocentric perspective previously hidden worlds. What is striking in these early modern texts—of monsters shown to the eye of the curious and the privities of women opened simultaneously to anatomical discovery and the pornographic gaze—is not only the crossings they negotiate between different contexts and discourses (or in the case of the anatomists' references to Africanus, between domestic and exotic, Europe and "Barbary") but also the shared language of opening, uncovering, or bringing to light something characterized at the same time as monstrous or obscene. The language of opening to the eye's inspection what had been secret, closed, or hid characterizes European discovery narratives from the beginning. Its wider context is the emphasis on "ocularly recognizing" that links accounts of the uncovering of previously unknown worlds to the language of early modern science and anatomy. Both—in their conflating of an epistemological with a visual hunger, the desire to know as the desire to see—depend upon even as they transform the older but still powerful language of the "eye" of God "to whom nothing is hidden."³⁵

The presentation of Leo Africanus to his English audience is marked throughout, for example, by this emphasis on the ocular, or what might reliably provide its surrogate. John Pory's English translation of *A Geographical Historie of Africa Written in Arabicke and Italian by Iohn Leo a More* (1600) literally enacts the experience of unfolding and exposing to the eye, including in its prefatory materials a map of Africa folded and closed

upon itself, which, when opened up, brings before the reader's gaze the land of monsters, of Amazons, of prodigious sexuality and of peoples who expose those parts that should be hid.³⁶ Its frontal material evokes the desire to see and know "the secrets and particularities of this African part of the world," which it promises to disclose "at large" through Africanus's narrative "now *plainely discovered and laide open to the view of all beholders*." To the narrative of this African *Historie*—the first to open the interior of Africa to European inspection—is affixed an "approbation of the historie ensuing" by none other than Richard Hakluyt, the veteran of New World discovery who persuaded Pory to undertake the translation of Africanus into English. It affirms this traveler's narrative to be "the verie best, the most particular, and methodocall, that ever was written, or at least hath *come to light* concerning the countries, peoples, and affaires of Africa." And it is joined in this same preface by reference to the account of "John Baptista Ramusius, Secretarie to the State of Venice," treating of the manifold difficulties he had earlier undergone in order "to bring the important discourses therein *to light*."³⁷

The "secrets and particularities" of unknown parts of the world were visually displayed not just by the opening of pages or unfolding of maps but by the early modern textual innovation of an index—a term still heavy in this period with its etymological sense of "informer"—an indicator or pointer that made the contents of these massive volumes even more accessible to ready survey by the eye. One text promises, for example, to bring before its reader the "laws, customes, and manners of all nations . . . collected, abridged, digested, and compacted together in this short and compendious Breviary; wherein you may easily finde whatever you have occasion to looke for . . . *lying open before thine eyes*."³⁸ Travelers and discoverers were informers to a European audience, bringing reports of matters otherwise hidden and unseen—an ocular emphasis that frequently makes the activity of reporting on the foreign or exotic one of informing in the sense of espial or spying out. Hakluyt himself calls upon this complex when he urges English voyagers to Virginia (simultaneously named after Elizabeth the Virgin Queen and suggestive of yet unopened virgin territory) to strive "with *Argus eies* to see" what this virgin territory might be made to "yield," a visual language of espial (as well as appropriation or ownership) reminiscent of the sexualized currency both of such discovery narratives and of other contemporary discourses.³⁹

It is this shared language of discovery, then, that gives to these exotic traveler's tales their affinities with the ocular preoccupations of the grow-

ing domestic network of delators, informers, and spies, charged with reporting on the secret or hid, less accessible to "ocular proof." Pory reproduces from "Ramusius" an account that speaks of the delight of the European audience of Africanus's *Historie* to have unfolded through it a report "Concerning which part of the world even till these our daies, we have had no knowledge in a manner out of any other author, or at leastwise never any *information so large*" (in the early modern sense of dilated or set out at large) or "of so *undoubted truth*."⁴⁰ Pory's promise to unfold at large parts of Africa previously hidden from view is a promise to bring what had been hidden, or revealed only in part, before his English readers' eyes. But the gaze is a vicarious gaze, the substitution of narrative or report for what a later such text would call the eyewitness or "ocular . . . view."⁴¹ The principal criterion for such substitutes for the directly ocular (in this as in the judicial sphere) therefore became their reliability as testimony. Not only did they need to provide lifelike description, bringing the unseen as if before the eye through verbal *enargeia* or the rhetorical creation of convincing pictures (the root of seeing or illustration that links *enargeia*—or *evidentia*—to the "*Argus*" of the many eyes); they also needed to be trustworthy informers. Yet it is precisely the reliability of their testimony that was repeatedly called into question. Proliferating accounts of the monsters and prodigies of foreign lands circulated in the early modern period in an environment prey to the danger, and ever-present accusation, of counterfeit report, of substitutes for ocular proof that put the reader in "false gaze," the phrase used at the beginning of *Othello* for the false report of Signior Angelo (generic name for "messenger") that ominously anticipates the falsified informing of Iago.⁴² What the English translator of one travel text calls the "multitude of Mandivels" that "wander abroad in this pamphletting age in the habite of sincere Historiographers," relating "meere probabilities for true," casts doubt on all reports of matters so "*monstrous and prodigious*, as they appear utterly voide of credit."⁴³

Leo Africanus was one of these informing messengers, bearing tales from territories formerly off the stage of European history. Pory's presentation of his report thus raises more than once what appear to be needed "vouches" or warrants of his reliability, in an age it too notes is populated by "mountebanks and Mandevilles." His prefatory "To the Reader" presents this African narrator as worthy "to be regarded" because, although "by birth a More, and by religion for many yeeres a Mahumetan," his "conversion to Christianitie," along with "his busie and dangerous travels," render him a reliable informer on matters that before "were either

utterly concealed, or unperfectly and fabulously reported."⁴⁴ Africanus's own narrative, in Pory's translation, repeatedly invokes the language and authority of the eyewitness, or where ocular proof is unavailable, the testimony of the informer whose information bears the stamp of truth. Its "vouches" are filled with the sense of narrative bringing vicariously before the gaze, as a credible substitute for the directly ocular:

These are the things memorable and woorthie of knowledge seene and observed by me John Leo, throughout al Africa, which countrey I have in all places travelled quite over: wherein whatsoever I sawe woorthy the observation, I presently committed to writing: and those things which I sawe not, I procured to be *at large declared* unto me by most *credible and substantiall persons*, which were themselves *eie-witnesses* of the same. (358)

As Pory's presentation of Africanus's traveler's narrative to his English audience makes clear, that which is narratively declared or opened at large becomes a substitute for what the eye has not seen, as well as testimony whose reliability must be vouched for.



This would not be believ'd in Venice,
Though I should swear I saw't.

Othello

Othello has long been linked both with Mandeville's "fabulous" reports and with the African *Historie* of Leo Africanus, the converted Moor, through the "travellours historie" (as the Folio text has it) provided by Othello the Moor of Venice in answer to the charges of witchcraft he is called to defend himself against before the Venetian senate in Act I.⁴⁵ It is this story of "Cannibals that each other eat, / The Anthropophagi, and men whose heads / Do grow beneath their shoulders" (I.iii.143-45) that Othello provides first to Brabantio, a prominent Venetian citizen eager to hear his tale, then in response to Desdemona's entreaty "That I would all my pilgrimage dilate, / Whereof by parcels she had something heard" (153-54), and finally (in its staging simultaneously) to a Venetian and English audience ignorant of events in a double sense by them unseen—the monsters and adventures of these exotic worlds and the offstage wedding (and in Iago's vivid *enargeia*, the imagined bedding) of a Venetian virgin by a "lascivious" Moor, an "extravagant and wheeling stranger / Of here and every where" (I.i.136-37). As a "travellours historie," its presentation evokes all of the contemporary associations of such tales—

the European appetite both for monsters and for report (synecdochally through the "greedy ear" of Desdemona that did "devour up" this stranger's discourse, subtly and chiastically linking this form of domestic consumption with the figures of the "Cannibals" in these same lines); the converted Moor whose narrative is accepted as a reliable testimony or "vouch" (I.iii.106) of places and events of which his European audience has no direct eyewitness or "ocular proof"; and, later, the questioning of its credibility as report, when Iago (the figure who will soon become a "domestic" informer in every sense) charges that the Moor's tales are mere "bragging and telling . . . fantastical lies" (II.i.223).⁴⁶

The links between Othello's dilated traveler's history—its verbal pictures bringing offstage events vicariously before the eye—and his informer Iago's manipulation of verbal *evidentia* (vicarious substitute for ocular evidence) when attention subsequently turns to the domestic secrets of a Venetian woman, become part of this play's own extraordinary emphasis on the hunger to know as the desire to see, its obsession with offstage events domestic and exotic, related both to the sexualizing of the chamber of a woman and to the history of an outsider Moor. The two combine in the vivid fantasies of coupling exploited in the opening scene, in Iago and Roderigo's verbal evocations of "an old black ram / . . . tuppung your white ewe." They continue in the relation between Othello's dilation of his traveler's history and his own hunger to see and know through the medium of *his* native informant, to spy out the secrets of a woman whose "honor" is described as "an essence that's *not seen*" (IV.i.16).

The play itself suggests—in a single striking verbal echo—this chiasmic crossing of foreign and domestic, exotic and sexual. The "travellours' historie" provided by the Moor in answer to Desdemona's entreaty that he "all [his] pilgrimage dilate" (I.iii.153) has its unmistakable echo in the sexualized object of the "close dilations" of the temptation scene (III.iii.123), where Iago, Venetian informer on these more domestic secrets, begins to unfold not hidden exotic worlds but the close or secret place of Desdemona's sexuality that his informing promises to bring to "light" (I.iii.404). It is these close dilations (with their pun on the dilations or secret accusations of the informer and their beginning, like Othello's dilated narrative, from what is first glimpsed only in "parcels" or in part) that lead to the Moor's conviction that this informer "sees and knows more, much more, than he *unfolds*" (III.iii.242–43). The language of dilating, opening, or unfolding (enacted in Pory's presentation of Africanus's exotic *Historie*, with its folded map and its promise to open or dilate

at large what has been hidden from the eye) begins, as *Othello* narrows to domestic secrets, to mark this new hunger to bring before the eye something unseen, offstage, hid—a movement that leads first to the napkin or handkerchief that both substitutes for ocular proof and increases the appetite for it, and finally to Desdemona's hidden chamber, only in the final act brought forth to show.



'Tis an essence that's not seen.

Othello

The double sense, then, of *dilate* in early modern usage—both as opening or enlarging something constricted or closed and opening “more fully to the gaze” something folded or hid—is invoked in the scene of *Othello*'s own exotic “travellours historie,” as are the links with the close dilations that evoke a hunger to see and know. It is this simultaneously eroticized and epistemological impulse to open up to show that enables the easy movement between rhetorical and sexual opening exploited in the link between *Othello*'s evocation of tales of African or New World discovery and the simultaneously visual and sexual close dilations of Iago's domestic informing, vicariously exposing a hidden place (or “fault”) and crime. To return to the close dilations of the temptation scene from these several contemporary contexts of discovery—exotic (or “barbarous”) worlds formerly beyond the reach of European eyes, the anatomical opening of a secret female place, the nascent apparatus of judicial discovery, and the world of the delator and spy—is to approach the simultaneously sexual, judicial, and epistemological impulses of opening, dilating, and discovering to the view that combine so powerfully in this play. It might indeed be said that *Othello* trains the domestic *political* activity of the delator, privy informer, and accuser, on the domestic *private* sphere of a hidden chamber and female secret place, in ways that invoke not just the language of a crime or fault to be uncovered but a simultaneously prurient and deeply ambivalent fascination with the close or privy locus of female sexuality, opened, unfolded, brought forth to show. The scene of Iago's close dilations thus resonates with the sense of something too monstrous or hideous to be shown, as with the sexual sense of “queynte” already summoned ambiguously in Sonnet 20 and awakened here by the description of Cassio as one “acquainted” with *Othello*'s wife (III.iii.99). The partial glimpses that lead to the Moor's suspicion that his informer “Sees and knows more, much more than he unfolds” (243) culminate in the demand for “ocular

proof" (360) from an informer whose report and circumstantial evidence promise to lead him to a "door of truth" (407) linked with the privy chamber of a woman.

Within the almost unbearably protracted temptation scene, the close dilations that lead to this demand for show find their echo in a later passage whose terms are strikingly both epistemological and sexual:

IAGO: My lord, I would I might entreat your honor
 To scan this thing no farther; leave it to time.
 Although 'tis fit that Cassio have his place—
 For sure he fills it up with great ability.
 (III.iii.244–47)

Hidden within the visual language of this informer's advice to "scan this thing no farther"—lines whose "thing" appears to designate simply the matter concerned (Desdemona's adultery)—is a "matter" that elsewhere in this scene is the "thing" or "common thing" (301–2) Emilia offers to her husband, the female privy or *res* that Iago vulgarly sexualizes when she intrudes to offer him what turns out to be the "trifle" of the handkerchief.⁴⁷ The advice against "scanning" this "thing," appearing to speak only to an epistemological hunger to see and know, introduces into the lines that follow the double meanings of the "place" Cassio "fills up" with "great ability," a place whose sexual inference is joined by the threat to Othello's "occupation" through the more obscene sense of "occupy."⁴⁸ "Scan this thing no farther" resonates with a *res* that is at once epistemological and sexual, as with a sense of scanning as the inspection of a matter or thing brought before the eye.⁴⁹ And what is secret or unseen here is the ambiguous sexual place of all of the double-meaning references to the place Cassio might occupy as Othello's placeholder or "lieutenant."⁵⁰

Hunger to know as the desire to see pervades the scene of Iago's partial or close dilations and Othello's "if thou dost love me / Show me thy thought," in lines that link hunger to see what is hidden within Iago's mind to an increasingly obsessed fascination with what lies hid within Desdemona's chamber. *Show*, as in *Hamlet*, is a term that already reverberates with sexual overtones—as in the pun on *shoe* and *shew* in *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, where the "shoe with the hole in it" is taken to represent his mother as the "worsor sole" (II.iii.14–18). At the same time, the almost tortuously condensed senses of "some monster in thy thought / Too hideous to be shown" register a double impulse like Crooke's presentation, "dilated and laide open" to the view, of something simultaneously "too obscene

to look upon." "Hideous," as Michael Neill has argued, is in this overdetermined complex virtually an equivalent for the Latinate "obscene," as that which according to a powerful though false etymology should be kept "offstage"—forging a link of sound between the *scaenum* or stage and the obscene as what should be hidden, unseen, not shown.⁵¹

Othello itself, however, provokes a constant, even lurid fascination with the offstage, hidden, or in this sense ob-scene, starting from the vividly racialized rhetoric of Iago and Roderigo focused on an unseen sexual coupling (or imagined coupling) involving the monstrous opening of a Venetian virgin by a "lascivious Moor." Much of its language, from this visually evocative rhetoric at its opening ("old black ram . . . tugging your white ewe") keeps attention centered on the offstage and unseen, the sexual opening of Desdemona as a virgin on her wedding night or, once Iago's inferences and close dilations begin, as a potentially already "open" and too "liberal" woman. The fact that this opening is happening offstage and hence barred from more direct or ocular access prompts what mounts in the play both as a hunger for yet more narrative or report—the desire of now another "hungry ear" that an informer might "all [his narrative] dilate"—and as a desire that the hidden, close, or secret be brought forth to show. The audience of the play—and its critics—get caught up in its obsessive reference to this offstage, hidden scene, inaccessible to what Lacan called the eye's *invidia*. Obsession with what is available only in "close dilations" or partial glimpses—and the hunger to have dilated at large what has been glimpsed only in "parcels" or in part (I.iii.154)—becomes in *Othello* the powerful dramatic counterpart of the obsessive scopophilia of jealousy, its obsession with glimpses possible only through a tantalizing *jalousie*, a link also forged in the language of rhetorical dilation as showing first through a "lattice" before opening more fully to the gaze.⁵²



My mother had a maid call'd Barbary.

Othello

Othello's dilated travelers' tale, opening to Venetian (and English) eyes exotic worlds beyond the direct reach of vision, combined with the close dilations of a Venetian informer on the secrets of Desdemona's chamber, chart the crossing in this play of domestic and exotic, explicitly within the register of fascination and the vicariously visual. The evocation of a female *res* or thing available to be "dilated and laide open" to the eye in

Iago's "scan this thing no farther" links it to the language applied elsewhere to Othello the Moor ("the sooty bosom / Of such a *thing* as thou," I.ii.70–71), a language that returns beyond this play in the description of Caliban (possible anagram of "cannibal") as the "thing of darkness" Prospero calls his own.⁵³ Both sexualized and racialized "thing," along with desire to bring the hidden forth to "show," converge in the trifling thing Emilia offers to her husband—the handkerchief or "napkin" that becomes the sign at once of Desdemona's unseen honor (IV.i.16) and of Othello's exotic history, linked with Africa and Egypt ("that handkerchief / Did an Egyptian to my mother give"; "there's magic in the web of it," III.iv.55–58, 69ff.). Embroidered "alla moresca" in Cinthio, the play's Italian source, and "spotted with strawberries" (III.iii.435) in Shakespeare's addition, it evokes, as Lynda Boose has argued, a form of bringing forth to show the hidden sexual place of woman specifically linked with an opened or lost virginity, the "bloody napkin" that figures not just in exotic or African narratives but as a resonance within domestic European anxieties surrounding the secrets of female sexuality. The "bloody linnen cloth" described by "Leo the Affrican" is cited in the English translation of Ambroise Paré in the context not just of virginity but of the "deceit of bauds and harlots," who "having learned the most filthy and infamous arts of bawdry" seek to make men "to beleve that they are pure virgins"—an accusation of deceit that resonates against "I took you for that cunning whore of Venice / That married with Othello" (IV.ii.89–90) in the speech of another converted Moor.⁵⁴ In *Othello*, the evidence of the spotted napkin presented as a substitute for direct or ocular proof conjures in a single powerfully condensed image a token of opened virginity, suspicion of a chamber kept by a "bawd," and the exoticized history of a stranger Moor, split between an outside condemned as barbarous and the perspective of a Venetian husband informed of secrets that in Venice are not only monstrous but withheld from show, except to the eye of God ("In Venice they do let God see the pranks / They dare not show their husbands," III.iii.202–3).

Through the pun on matter and female matrix that runs through *Hamlet* as through *Othello*, the handkerchief is also paired syntactically with something that is "the matter" (DESDEMONA: I will, so. What's the matter? / OTHELLO: That handkerchief," V.ii.47–48). As a "thing" that *can* be scanned and seen, it makes the invisible visible, standing, as "trifle," for a female "particular" otherwise out of the field of vision, forging sound links with the open hand of Desdemona that argues something else too

open and too "liberal." As the visible counterpart to the *rhetorical* uncovering of the lines on Cassio and Desdemona "Naked in bed" (IV.i.1-5)—narrative that *appears* to bring something offstage before the eye—it is associated with the exposure of secrets, standing in for "an essence that's not seen" (IV.i.16) and figuring a magical ability "almost [to] read / The thoughts of people" (III.iv.57-58). As a form of show that renders the private public, it appears to expose the "villainous secrets" for which Emilia is the "closet lock and key" (IV.ii.22) and thus to *publish* Desdemona's crime, offering a "thing" or "common thing" that makes this "privie" female place into a common place, provoking Othello's "O thou *public commoner*" (IV.ii.73) as he delivers the judgment Iago's informing finally brings him to.

In the desire for show or ocular proof that begins with the "close dilations" of Act III, Iago plays both informer on a hidden crime, invoking all the language of judicial "proofs" (III.iii.430), and pander to the simultaneously horrified and fascinated gaze. The partial glimpses offered by his informing lead toward the offstage chamber of Desdemona's sexuality and assumed offense. But the double impulse that in an anatomist like Crooke involves both the exposure of a "privity dilated or laide open" to the view and the sense that it is a place "too obscoene to look upon" also informs desire in *Othello* at once to see and to avert the eye. The sense of disgust conveyed in Othello's "she with Cassio hath the *act of shame* / A thousand times committed" (V.ii.211-12) and the metaphorical displacements of his description of Iago as an "honest man" who "hates the slime / That sticks on filthy deeds" (148-49) resonate, as Edward Snow has argued, with disgust at the sexual act itself, with what Crooke terms "so obscoene a businesse" in a text that also describes the female orifice in particular as something "obscoene."⁵⁵

We have noted (in relation to the resonances of the close dilations of the temptation scene) the ambivalence involved in the sexual as well as rhetorical opening or enlargement of a woman, together with its relation to the anxieties surrounding adultery, fear that a closed virgin, once opened, might be enfranchised or at large. In this sense, the dilation or opening of a "privie" female place also involves something threatening to the privy or private as sole possession or private property, to closure and enclosure at once. The sense that a woman can be either closed or dangerously open hovers in *Othello* around the association of Desdemona with the women of Venice in particular, simultaneously a "Virgin Citie" and the "wide world's common place," famous for its courtesans. Venice, on

Europe's margins, was also the port of entry or opening to Africa, and hence, like Cyprus—under Turkish control by the time of the play—associated with an opening to a barbarous or monstrous outside, a link between sexual invasion or opening and vulnerability to “barbary” explicitly forged within the play by Brabantio’s “So let the Turk of Cyprus us beguile” when his Venetian daughter has been taken by an “erring barbarian.”⁵⁶

The sense of something open rather than more chastely closed also underlies the exploitation in *Othello* of links between the two traditionally associated female orifices: closed or silent mouth and female “lap” or “privitie,” both suspect, and threatening, in their potential liberality. Desdemona’s “parleying” early in Act II—in a scene filled with reference to the too “liberal” female tongue, mouth, and lips, and to women’s proverbial propensity to “disclose” secrets (II.i.156)—links her with the topos of the too open and unsecret female mouth (as will her resolution, later, to “talk Othello out of patience”), while the attendant suggestion of sexual openness, her “parley to provocation” (II.iii.23) as Iago tellingly puts it, is a link made sotto voce in the climaxing of this exchange with the hint of “strumpet” in “The Moor! I know his trumpet” (II.i.178). In relation to this threatening openness of *o* and mouth, Desdemona is silenced as well as made more passive-obedient in order simply to affirm her chastity as the play proceeds, in contrast to the frankness of her speech at the beginning, when, asking for an “ear” to her “unfolding” (I.iii.244), she had expressed desire for the “rites” of a marriage resulting from her own will. The form of her death, then—in a striking departure from the play’s source (where she is killed by blows)—becomes the closing or stifling of her mouth, an act that makes explicit the links between the two orifices throughout, a symbolic “close” both to her speech and to the assumed crime of sexual openness enacted on her wedding sheets.

The sense of closing—or attempting to close—what has been opened, in this linking of the *O* of a woman’s secret place with the openness of her mouth, gathers force as the tragedy moves to its own close, in the increasingly insistent references to the stopping of women’s mouths: in the desire to keep Bianca from railing “in the streets” (IV.i.163) and in Iago’s command to Emilia to “speak *within door*” and “charm” her tongue before she finally, too late, determines to be “liberal” in her speech (V.ii.219–22). In relation to the stage directing of Iago as the Moor’s sole informer, the attempt to charm or stop female tongues and other tongues as the play proceeds toward its “bloody period” parallels this informer’s

need to prevent what is called a further "unfolding" (V.i.21). In this sense, the closing down that takes over as the tragedy rushes toward its own close involves a closing off of further dilation or increase, not just stopping mouths but putting an end to Desdemona's threateningly open sexuality, along with the nightmare of increase ("a thousand times committed") glimpsed through the *jalousie* of Iago's informing. As a foreclosing of increase, the scene of her death (with all of its images of symbolically regained virginity) echoes the desire for closure and perfection already expressed in the scene of parleying in Act II—where Othello's yearning for death ("If it were now to die") stands in striking contrast to Desdemona's "The heavens forbid / But that our loves and comforts should *increase* / Even as our days do *grow*" (II.i.193–95).

The impulse to see and open up to show—driving obsession with what is offstage and hidden from the eye—is countered correspondingly as *Othello* moves to this close by the impulse to close off or hide from sight. The play repeatedly eroticizes the offstage chamber linked with Desdemona's sexuality and hidden behind a door before that chamber, and its bed, are finally uncovered (if only partially) to vision in the play's last scene. But when what has been offstage, ob-scene, and hidden is finally brought forth to show, it is only after this privy/ob-scene female place has been indicted. "Enter Othello, [with a light,] and Desdemona in her bed" is the stage direction in the Folio (supplemented by the "light" of the First Quarto) reproduced in most modern editions. But what is in this almost literal sense finally exposed or brought to light—the hidden place of Desdemona's sexuality and her "crime" (V.ii.26)—is, almost as soon as it is shown, rehidden and reclosed. The lines simultaneously bespeak desire to "Put out the light, and then put out the light" (V.ii.7), a sense that emerges in the gesture of repressing that extends to the whole of the spectacle the play has exposed, in the lines addressed by Lodovico to Iago, the simultaneous informer and pander responsible for this "show": "Look on the tragic loading [Q1, lodging] of this bed; / This is thy work. The object *poisons sight*, / Let it be *hid*" (V.ii.363–65).

The final scene that leads to Desdemona's stifling in the bed she has "defil'd," one that invokes the satisfying of a justice ("The justice of it pleases"), begins with Othello's "It is the cause, it is the cause, my soul; / Let me not name it to you, you chaste stars," and then repeats "It is the *cause*" (V.ii.1–3). The judicial resonance of this repeated "cause" summons the judicial language so pervasive through the play, here invoked to authorize a husband as final judge and executioner of a too open and

too "liberal" wife ("she must die, else she'll betray more men," V.ii.6). But the cause that cannot be named to these "chaste stars" also hides a language that has lurking within it the threateningly open "case" of an unchaste woman, through a complex interlingual pun on *cause*, *case*, *chose* and *thing*, the obscene, unnameable "case" of a woman whose opening provides the justifying "cause" of her death and the judicial proceeding of a husband against a female "chose" or thing that cannot be named to stars figuring the virginal coldness of a closed perfection.⁵⁷ Female case and legal cause are linked elsewhere in Shakespeare, before and after the staging of this scene.⁵⁸ But in this tragic context, what began as the opening of this case in the close dilations of Iago's informing here in the lines that move from "It is the cause" to "Put out the light" becomes, in every sense, a final closing of the case, an opening of the closed chamber of Desdemona's sexuality only to execute upon it the "foregone conclusion" (III.iii.428) of a predetermined justice. Othello's "It is the cause, it is the cause" powerfully summons the tragic sense throughout the play of a monstrous parallel between a process of judgment, where the information laid by a secret accuser is enough to result in the death of the accused, and the suppressed, subliminal language of the sexual cause or case, something—secret, close, occult—always indicted in advance.⁵⁹

The tragedy that leads from Iago's tantalizingly partial or close dilations to Othello's demand for ocular proof ends with a gesture of repression and reclosing, expressed not only by the desire that something that "poisons sight" be "hid" but by this informer's "Demand me nothing" (V.ii.303), its verbal or rhetorical counterpart.⁶⁰ The play that began with "Tush, never tell me" and with reference to the opening of a "purse" both opens up to show and then recloses, as if there were an underground link between the dilating or opening of a secret place to view and the theatrical show that (as in the root of "*theatrical*") depends on the sense of something viewed or seen.⁶¹ Before we consider the fuller implications of this link, however, we need now to turn to *Hamlet*, a play that draws an explicit connection between the spying out of secrets, dramatic spectacle, and female show.



Her clothes spread wide.

Hamlet

In the midst of *Hamlet*, in the scene meant to "catch the conscience of the King," Hamlet initiates an exchange with Ophelia filled with ob-

scene double entendres, first on *lap* and then on *shew* or *show*. The exchange begins with "Lady, shall I lie in your lap?" (III.ii.112), a question made more bawdy by the reference in both Folio and Second Quarto to "country matters," obscenely invoking a female "matter," *count* or "cunt," and the "nothing" that lies "between maids' legs" (116–19). It continues as this "nothing" is iterated in Hamlet's "For O, for O, the hobby-horse is forgot" and then, following the dumb show and its "show of protestation" made by a queen, in the concluding double entendres on the meaning of this show:

OPHELIA: What means this, my lord?

HAMLET: Marry, this' miching mallecho, it means mischief.

OPHELIA: Belike this show imports the argument of the play.

Enter Prologue

HAMLET: We shall know by this fellow. The players cannot keep counsel, they'll tell all.

OPHELIA: Will a' tell us what this show meant?

HAMLET: Ay, or any show that you will show him. Be not you ashamed to show, he'll not shame to tell you what it means.

(136–46)

The obscene play on *show* or *shew* here exploits, once again, the links between dramatic show and female show, heightened (as in *Two Gentlemen*) by the possibility of a pun on *shoe* referring to a woman's sexual part.⁶² Both the initial reference to a female "lap" (or "o") and the obscene sense of a place Ophelia may be "ashamed to show" hover, then, around the dumb show of a play designed both to "catch the conscience of the King" (II.ii.605) and to bring his "occulted guilt" (III.ii.80) to light.

The lines that feature both the obscener sense of female show and a "show of Protestation" (F) by a player queen also include concern that a secret will be let out, that "players" who "cannot keep counsel" will "tell all." Hamlet's "The players cannot keep counsel, they'll tell all," just before Ophelia's "Will 'a tell us what this show meant?" bespeaks an inability to keep counsel or secrets that elsewhere in Shakespeare, as in other early modern writing, is most often the proverbial inability of women in particular to keep from disclosing what should be hid, a clear link with the secret sexual place they are to guard from show. The "shew" of the dumb show authorizes a whole play here on *show* and *tell* as different forms of revealing secrets, telling all or opening to view what is otherwise hid, linking players whose art is to make things public or expose to show

with an assumed female inability to keep things close or secret.⁶³ The links established in this scene, designed both to catch the conscience of the king and to bring to light the information and reliability of the Ghost, continue into the immediate aftermath of this onstage show—first in Hamlet's exchange with Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, informers sent to "pluck out the heart of [his] mystery" (III.ii.365–66), then in the aborted confession of Claudius in the prayer scene, unable except in secret to disclose his guilt, and then in Gertrude's interview with Hamlet, not in the public, open space of the earlier dramatic show but in the private space of a mother's closet, where the woman whose sexuality and secrets are so much the focus of the play is warned by her son that she must not reveal what transpires privily within it.

In the closet scene itself, the link between a female matter and revealing secrets from a closet is suggested first in the harping, just before, on "matter" and "mother" (*mater*)—in Hamlet's "but to the matter: my mother" (324), as Rosencrantz and Guildenstern deliver their message that his mother "desires to speak with [him] in her closet ere [he goes] to bed" (331), and in his repeated "Now, mother, what's the matter" (III.iv.8) as he enters it.⁶⁴ The link is even more strikingly suggested in the tortured syntax of Hamlet's desire that his mother not "ravel" a secret "matter" out, in lines that evoke both her sexuality and her bed:

Not this, by no means, that I bid you do:
 Let the bloat king tempt you again to bed,
 Pinch wanton on your cheek, call you his mouse,
 And let him, for a pair of reechy kisses,
 Or paddling in your neck with his damn'd fingers,
 Make you to ravel all this matter out,
 That I essentially am not in madness,
 But mad in craft.

(181–88)

"Mouse" here—a more privy term for "woman"—and Hamlet's reiterated concern for the keeping of secrets (in the "sense and secrecy" that might "such dear concernings hide," 191–92), forge clear verbal links between the matter/mother of this closet scene and the description of players who cannot "keep counsel" in the scene of the *Mouse-trap* set to disclose or ravel out a secret or "occulted guilt." The scene in Gertrude's closet picks up echoes from this earlier scene of "show" and "tell," just as it anticipates the language of Claudius's attempts to ferret precisely this woman's secret

out ("There's *matter* in these sighs, these profound heaves—/ You must *translate*," IV.i.1–2). For it is in this same closet that Polonius, come as informer to spy, is silenced as a potential exposé of its secrets, now not to be revealed by a "counsellor" or keeper of official secrets who as "a foolish *prating* knave" (III.iv.213–15) has been rendered "most still, most secret, and most grave" by the thrust that keeps him from informing on or telling all of what he has come to spy upon.

The sense of keeping counsel or secrets, begun in the exchange around the dumb show and its female "show," has reverberations both before and after this closet scene. Its echo sounds immediately after Polonius's death, when Rosencrantz and Guildenstern come to inquire where the body is hid ("HAMLET: Do not believe it. / ROSENCRANTZ: Believe what? / HAMLET: That I can *keep your counsel* and not mine own," IV.ii.9–10) and then, at the threshold of the mad scene of Ophelia, in the queen's aside on the spilling of her own "occulted guilt" ("To my sick soul, as sin's true nature is, / Each toy seems prologue to some great amiss, / So full of artless jealousy is guilt, / It spills itself in fearing to be spilt," IV.v.17–20). In the mad scene itself, Ophelia's bawdy songs, linked from the outset with a speech that is "nothing" (7), treat obsessively of something opened or let out. Warned earlier by Laertes that she not her "chaste treasure open" (I.iii.31), Ophelia sings of the opened "chamber doors" of maids ("And dupp'd the chamber-door, / Let in the maid, that out a maid / Never departed more," IV.v.53–55), just after lines whose "when they ask you what it means" (46–47) echo her "Will 'a tell us what this *show* meant?" (III.ii.143) in the scene of the dumb show that played repeatedly on a female "o" and was her last appearance upon the stage. In contrast to the "natural modesty" of women reported in Pliny and repeated in Crooke, Ophelia, in the "melodious lay" (IV.vii.182–83) of her drowning, floats more openly, face up, "her clothes spread wide" (175) in lines the ear may hear, given other such Shakespearean instances, as the spreading wide of her "*close*."⁶⁵

Ophelia's close or clothes spread wide display or open to the view what in the passage from Pliny cited by Crooke on the "Lap or Privities" should more modestly be hid. The spreading wide of a "close" in this sense joins the language of Polonius's "I'll *loose* my daughter to him" (II.ii.162) and the innuendoes of sexual enfranchisement in Hamlet's "Let her not walk i' the sun." It picks up the hints of sexual opening and closing in the double entendres of her songs, as in the description of "long purples / That *liberal* shepherds give a grosser name, / But our *cull-cold*

maids do dead men's fingers call" (IV.vii.169–71). Whether or not this buried sense of the opening of a "close"—with its echoes of Hamlet's double entendres on what Ophelia might be "asham'd to show"—gives support to Rebecca West's thesis of an already unchaste Ophelia is here beside the point. What matters is not so much the pre- or offstage history of a single character as the play's persistent harping on opening something closed, the attempts everywhere within it to ferret out secrets and disclose what is hid.⁶⁶ As with the possibility of the queen's adultery (or Desdemona's in *Othello*), what is at issue is fascination with unseen events, the obsession everywhere in *Hamlet* with spying and being spied upon linked with the secrets of women that can be exposed to show,⁶⁷ a fascination that makes women, marginalized as *characters* within the play, paradoxically central to it.



How all occasions do inform against me.

Hamlet

We need therefore to remark more concretely how closely bound up both the plot of *Hamlet* and its obsessive language of seeing are with the visual preoccupations of the contemporary world of informer and spy. Editors of the play routinely gloss Hamlet's "I see a cherub that sees them" when Claudius says to him "if thou knew'st our purposes" (IV.iii.47–48) by reference to the cherubim that have the gift to "see truly" in *Troilus and Cressida* (III.ii.70), the order of angels identified with knowledge and keenness of vision, as later in *Paradise Lost* ("watchful Cherubim; four faces each / Had, like a double Janus, all their shape / Spangled with eyes more numerous than those / Of Argus," 11.128–31). These angelic intelligences, however, and with them an older imagery of divine vision and intellection had, by the time of *Hamlet*, already been accommodated to the new context of "intelligence" as espial, to the "eyes" of statecraft as the "Argus eyes" of spies. Among the prayers to be read in churches upon the discovery of Dr. William Parry, an informant (and double agent) executed in 1585 for designs upon the life of the queen, was a prayer that praised the "vigilant eye" of providence for the "sudden interruption of his endeavour," when the vigilance in question was clearly that of a spy (he was informed against by a fellow conspirator), and the "vigilant eye" of providence a euphemism for state intelligence. We need here to recall the description from 1593 of the sheer omnipresence of "secret spies" who "give intelligence" of "secret intents"; or Walsingham's network of

informers, set up to "draw secrets from the conscience of the body politic."⁶⁸

Hamlet comes at this crucial historical juncture, the point where an older language of divine or angelic intelligence, or the eye of God, was being converted into the new lexicon of espial, and the "privy intelligences" provided by a progressively more organized network of informers and spies. Spying is everywhere in *Hamlet*, adding to the claustrophobia that pervades the world of the play (and that may be one of the resonances in the name of Claudius) and giving to it the sense at its end, in the advent of Fortinbras, of the arrival on stage of something like the beginnings of the modern state. Claudius sends Polonius, and then Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, to "pluck out the heart" of Hamlet's "mystery," to spy into the causes of his "antic disposition." Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes in Paris and extract a narrative from acquaintances in order to "make inquire" (II.i.4) into the private life of his own son. He demands to know of his daughter what was "between" her and Hamlet, reporting the results of this intelligence dutifully to the king and queen ("This in obedience hath my daughter *shown* me, / And more above, hath his solicitings, / As they fell out by time, by means, and place, / All given to mine ear," II.ii.125–28). The play on show and tell, eye and ear, exploited in the *Mousetrap* scene echoes throughout in these dual modalities of "informing." Spying with the eye and ferreting out a narrative are combined within the closet scene, where Polonius, come as spy, hides behind the arras in order to "hear" the "process" (in early modern English, "narrative") of what transpires. And the play ends by promising, beyond its own theatrical spectacle, the narrative of Horatio/*oratio* that is to report Hamlet's story faithfully to those who could not see or ocularly witness it.

"How all occasions do inform against me," laments Hamlet, using "inform" in the sense of impeach or accuse, in a soliloquy (IV.iv.32–66) not long after the scene of players who "tell all." "Who is't that can inform me?" asks Marcellus in the opening scene, opening the way to Horatio's exposition of a prior offstage history, the "source of this our watch, and the chief head / Of this post-haste and romage in the land" (I.i.106–7). So much of the play is in the interrogative mode—to invoke, but in a politically much more resonant context, the familiar phrase of Maynard Mack. The impulse that stands behind such questioning as Hamlet's address to the Ghost ("Say *why* is this? *wherefore*? *what* should we do?") frequently verges on what elsewhere in Shakespeare are called "interrogatories," forms of interrogation in a more aggressive sense, determination

to bring a mystery to light that involves the attempt to extract information or a narrative, to get a "questionable shape" to "speak" (I.iv.43–44). Once again, the emphasis on questioning, espial, and informing crosses with an epistemological hunger to see and know: the play is filled not just with spies but with what Polonius expresses as the desire to "find / Where truth is hid, though it were hid indeed / Within the centre" (II.ii.157–59), a hunger to ferret out mysteries shared, as with *Othello*, by the whole history of its criticism.

The sense of opening something hid to a show that will "tell all" links the play on show and tell around the dumb show with the iteration throughout *Hamlet* of the sense that secrets, or the hid, will finally out—from Hamlet's "Foul deeds will rise, / Though all the earth o'erwhelm them, to men's eyes" (I.ii.256–57), after Horatio tells him of the appearance of the Ghost, to his description of the "purpose" of players and the play meant to "catch the conscience of the King" (II.ii.605):

I have heard
That guilty creatures sitting at a play
Have by the very cunning of the scene
Been strook so to the soul, that presently
They have proclaim'd their malefactions:
For murther, though it have no tongue, will speak
With most miraculous organ.

(II.ii.588–94)

The show presented by players Hamlet predicts, when the Prologue appears, "cannot keep counsel" but will "tell all"—publishing secrets to both onstage and offstage audiences—is one that is to bring out into the open this "occulted guilt." The collocation of the two—bringing to light a hidden guilt and a prologue that indicates in brief what the show will present at large—sounds again in the lines in which Gertrude envisions the spilling of her secret "guilt" ("To my sick soul, as sin's true nature is, / Each toy seems *prologue* to some great amiss," IV.v.17–18).⁶⁹ The sense that the secret or occulted will come finally to light is countered, however, within the play by a powerful contrary sense of opacity, of inability to penetrate to the show beyond the show, of mysteries that cannot be uncovered or made visible to the eye.⁷⁰ This is the language of the Ghost's "But that I am forbid / To tell the *secrets* of my prison-house, / I could a tale *unfold* whose lightest word / Would harrow up thy soul" (I.v.13–16), or the soliloquy "To be or not to

be" with its evocation of contemporary travelers' tales in its description of death as an "undiscover'd country, from whose bourn / No traveller returns" (III.i.78-79). The Ghost, warning that "this eternal blazon must not be / To ears of flesh and blood" (I.v.21-22), goes on to a narrative unfolding or blazon meant to counter the "forged process" or lying narrative with which the "ear of Denmark" is "rankly abus'd" (36-38). But the play never offers ^{no} any perspicacious or unambiguous sense of a revelation beyond forgery, not ^{real} even in the player's oblique show of a hidden scene its commissioner seeks to bring unambiguously to light. ^{revelation}

The preoccupation with spying and informing in *Hamlet* as well as *Othello* raises the crucial question of the reliability of *evidence*, including substitutes for ocular proof, the problem that traversed so many contemporary early modern contexts, particularly where there was reliance on messengers or report. Recognition of opacity—of what could not, even on stage, be brought to light or forth to show—is part of what has been described as the "crisis of representation" in this period, a crisis of which the public theater functioned, paradoxically, as revelatory instrument. In this context, the obsessively staged desire to see or spy out secrets, or in the absence of the directly ocular, to extract a narrative that might provide a vicarious substitute implicates both show and tell, eye and ear, in the broader sixteenth- and early-seventeenth-century problem of testimony and report, the complexities of the relation between ocular proof and what in *Lear* is termed "auricular assurance" (I.ii.92), a problem shared by the lawcourts and other contestatory sites of epistemological or evidentiary certainty, of what might be reliably substituted for what could not be directly witnessed.⁷¹ The Ghost's narrative of hidden or unseen events, his informing on the primal scene of an offstage crime otherwise beyond the reach of vision, by raising the very possibility of a "forged process" or dissembling narrative anticipates the false report of Signior Angelo, the generic messenger (*angelus*) of *Othello*, who by putting the Venetians in "false gaze" prepares for the treacherous informing of Iago later in the play. But in both plays as well, the possibility of misrepresentation or forgery is also implicated in the problem of the reliability of the messenger or go-between.



Both the problem of the keeping or disclosing of secrets and the problem of the go-between in *Hamlet* are what make Jonathan Goldberg's

investigations of the office and function of the early modern "Secretarie" (or "Secretorie") so suggestive when placed beside this play, even apart from the more obvious links between the new emphasis on script and writing and a plot obsessed with both. The link between secrets and secretories is everywhere emphasized in the world contemporary with *Hamlet*, in contexts that overlap with secrecy in the realm of espionage and spies. The secretorie, as Angell Day puts it in *The English Secretorie*, is the keeper of "secrets or counsels," a trust that linked the office of principal secretary with the monarch's "closet" or "secret Cabinet."⁷² As "the closet, wherof another hath both the key, use and commandement," he ought to be "as a thicke plated doore, where through, without extraordinarie violence no man may enter, but by the locke which is the tongue" and "of such efficacie, as whereof no counterfeit key shoulde bee able to make a breach" (124). The opposite of this keeping of "secrets or counsels" is the untrustworthiness of those with "as little secrecie as silence," counselors whose "loosenes" of tongue means that they are incapable of keeping close, but, as with the players (or Polonius) will tell all (123).

What this description of the secretorie does when placed beside *Hamlet* is to evoke not only the link between secrets and their potential disclosers but, once again, the emergent world of statecraft contemporary with the play, one that historians describe as increasingly involving the mediation of agents, go-betweens and representatives across bureaucratic as well as geographical distances, along with the corresponding multiplication of informers and spies.⁷³ What the language of passages like this one from Day's *Secretorie* also demands, however, is to call attention to the sexualizing of an office associated with closets, secrets, and with standards of "fidelitie," with a key and doore only a "Lord and Master" might "breach." The secretorie is the "closet" of his lord, the place where this master deposits secrets, a description whose language of opening and entry evokes the secret matters of which women traditionally figure as ambiguous keepers, or more dangerously disclosers, part of an imagery that figures here—homoerotically—between men, in the affairs of state.⁷⁴ The secretary's keeping of counsel or secrets, including the secrets of power, is bound up with an imagery of the closeted or close, of silence and fidelity, that runs throughout the language of these descriptions, just as it does through the scene in *Hamlet* that links the players' inability to "keep counsel" or secrets with a female lap and show. It is to this, therefore, that we need once more to return.



The Queen, the Queen's to blame.

Janet Adelman

The exchange on "show" as *female* show in the dumb show of the play-within-a-play includes exploitation of the "nothing" or "o" of female sexuality, in the "lap" and "country matters" of Hamlet's obscenely suggestive lines. So concentrated is the evocation of a female matter exposed to show in this scene of doubled spectatorship that one of the variants an eighteenth-century commentator suggested for the "miching mallecho" of its most puzzling lines was "Malbecco," the figure of *Gelosia*, or Jealousy, whose specular obsessions involve not just spying generally but spying upon a woman.⁷⁵ However inappropriate the suggestion at the level of acceptable textual variant, the sense of spying into specifically female matters or secrets hovers around the doubled meanings of this dumb "shew," within a play that focuses relentlessly on the "frailty" and suspected adultery whose name is "woman."

Hamlet's fascination with seeing or uncovering the secrets of his mother has been the focus of much psychoanalytic criticism of the play—indeed, one of the founding texts of psychoanalysis itself.⁷⁶ This queen is the woman who betrays her son first as a mother, a woman whose sexuality is something secret or withheld from him, and then in the opacity and ambiguities of her complicity with Claudius, the man who killed his father and lay with his mother, though in which order is unclear. It is this that produces the sense in *Hamlet* that the play turns on the pivot of an offstage primal scene beyond the reach of vision, a scene on which gazing is forbidden, even in the deflected re-presentation of the player's "show"—the reason, perhaps, why this *dramatic* show includes its bitter double entendres on the "o" or "no-thing" that is woman. This desire to open up to "shew" involves the sense of a fault or crime that, at least as centrally as Claudius's, involves an offstage secret the entire play comes belatedly after and then attempts recursively to bring to light. In a pun on lap and *lapsus* that joins the punning on fault and fall linked to the play's fallen Edenic imagery—the sin of origin in a frail and "faulty" mother—the "o" or lap of woman in the *Mousetrap* scene invokes the *lapsus* or falling off of woman more generally, the sexual cleft or fault that is both the frailty of woman and her crime.⁷⁷ Critics of *Hamlet* have sensed the centrality of Gertrude and Ophelia to this play even when, as characters, they are marginalized by what appears to be taking center stage—the reliability of the Ghost,

or Hamlet and Claudius as "mighty opposites."⁷⁸ Criticism informed by psychoanalysis has focused especially on Gertrude. I want, however, to supplement the suggestive but necessarily universalizing paradigms of psychoanalysis (which follow *from* as much as they provide interpretive paradigms *for* this play), with an historically more immediate model in which woman, and the mother in particular, represents a matter, lapse, or fault that comes *between*, one that also links the resonances of secrets in this play to the contemporary world of agents and intermediaries, go-betweens, and spies.

Hamlet swears his mother, in her closet, to secrecy against her husband, in lines that underscore the link between a female matter and a close or secret matter not to be revealed or "ravelled out." When Claudius presses her to disclose what has transpired in that private place ("There's matter in these sighs, these profound heaves, / You must translate"), the terms of his questioning echo Hamlet's invocation in the *Mousetrap* scene of the translator or interpreter (III.ii.246), the figure who goes between (*inter-pres*) in a different sense.⁷⁹ The play draws repeated attention to something that is not just "the matter" but the "matter *between*," as in Polonius's "What is the matter, my lord?" in Act II and Hamlet's responding "Between who?" (II.ii.193–94). "Matter" here is something that comes between, just as the play on "country matters" and *matter/mater/mother* before the closet scene is linked with a female matter, the matrix of both sexuality and increase.

This female matter also, however, comes between. Hamlet's "Now, mother, what's the matter?" comes just after Polonius counsels this mother to remind her son that she has "stood between / Much heat and him" (III.iv.3–7). There is an even more striking juxtaposition of woman and a frail or "baser matter" that might be interposed or come between in the commission Hamlet-father delivers to Hamlet-son, a passage to which we have alluded in previous chapters and now need to quote in full:

thy commandment all alone shall live
Within the book and volume of my brain,
Unmix'd with *baser matter*. Yes, by heaven!
O most *pernicious woman*!

(I.v.102–5)

Beyond the generalized oedipal paradigms of a mother who "comes between" a father and son as the object of rivalry (elicited more readily from

Hamlet by the shift from brother to nephew as the murderer in the *Mousetrap* scene), the reference here to mixture with a "baser matter" summons the specific historical resonance of Aristotelian notions of female frailty as a matter or *materia* that comes between father and son in a different sense.⁸⁰ In a generative context, this female matter is the "woman's part" in man (as *Cymbeline* has it, II.v.20) that undermines and adulterates the perfect copying or reproduction of parthenogenesis—a lapse in what might otherwise be the replication of Hamlet-father in Hamlet-son. In the influential tradition of woman as faulty, imperfect, and secondary, a *lapsus* or falling off from the more perfect male, she is both baser matter and adulterating mixture, a frail or "weaker vessel" whose coming between involves an aberrant and translative detour, a creature whose status is also figured by sexual parts that are secret, occult, or hidden from the eye.⁸¹ In this historically contemporary model of the female matrix (as remarked in a different context in chapter 5), the matter of woman thus comes between—as *lapsus*, error, detour, frailty—the generative reproduction of a paternal original in a son who might otherwise be a faithful copy or representative, perfect instrument of a father's will.⁸²

Angell Day's faithful secretorie as the bearer, conveyer, or translator of messages is also to be the perfect copyist ("His pen in this action is not his owne"), "utterlie to relinquish anie affectation to his own doings" or admixture of his own will, avoiding "all maner of delaies" in the interest of "speedie conveyance" or dispatch" (130). The baser matter or mother who in this sense comes between opens by contrast a space of error or increase not just between father and son, but between a paternal script, commandment, or commission and its fulfillment. This is perhaps why Hamlet in his own delay as his father's agent, secretorie or messenger castigates himself for the "woman's part" within ("This is most brave, / That I, the son of a dear father murdered, / Prompted to my revenge by heaven and hell, / Must like a whore unpack my heart with words, / And fall a-cursing like a very drab," II.ii.582–86).

Hamlet, as we have seen, begins with reference to the conveyance or faithful transmission of a message, not only in the commission to Hamlet to represent his father's will—a commandment not to be mixed with baser matter—but in the commission given by the king to *his* agents or representatives, with a command (like Hamlet's to the players) that they not deviate from their script: "Giving to you no further personal power / To business with the King [of Norway], more than the scope / Of these [Q2: delated; F: dilated] articles allow" (I.ii.36–38). Claudius's commission

thus introduces early into *Hamlet* the very complex we began from in *Othello*, the link between dilation (F) and delation (Q2), in lines that have provoked a similar editorial controversy. When the Second Quarto's "delated articles" appear as the chosen text in most modern editions, it is as a variant in spelling for the sense of something rhetorically amplified or set forth at large.⁸³ This is the form of dilation echoed in Claudius's commission to the king of England in Act V ("an exact command, / Larded with many several sorts of reasons," ii.19–20) and parodied in Hamlet's amplifying *as's* in the commission (V.ii.38–47) that sends Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths.

The suggestion of the sense of "accusations" in the Second Quarto's "delated"—counterpart to Dr. Johnson's for the "close dilations" of *Othello*—was made for *Hamlet* by John Dover Wilson, in a reading whose controversial history led to its rejection by most editors. Claudius's articles are clearly "dilated" here, part of the amplified or "larded" style of this "bloat" king that Hamlet copies in Act V. But portmanteau words like these in Shakespeare routinely work in excess of their immediate context; and the overtone of accusation—whether or not appropriate for the message Claudius sends to accuse a rebellious nephew—is not at all inappropriate at the beginning of a play heavy with the sense of secrets and of hidden crimes, or a reign troubled by another nephew. Claudius's commission to his messengers—giving them "no further personal power" than "these delated/dilated articles allow"—appears in the First Quarto, moreover, as no more power than these "*related* articles do *shew*," lines that convey the combination of *show* and narrative relating or *tell* that will surface in the show and tell of the *Mousetrap* scene, where a play designed to bring forth this same king's "occulted guilt" has as the very "purpose of playing" delating or informing upon a hidden crime.



The play's the thing
Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the King. . . .
The king is a thing . . .
Of nothing.

Hamlet

In *Hamlet*—as, in different ways, in *Othello*—the language of dilation and delation, amplifying and indicting, links the matter of woman to other matters, including other figures who come *between*. Spying, opacity, and the language of secrets and "privities" inform the obsessive circlings of

this play around a mystery that only obliquely, or ambiguously, is ever brought to light, an ob-scene or offstage tableau the play attempts, but finally fails, to bring forth to show, displacing it at the end to still more narration, relation, or report. Both explicitly in the *Mousetrap* scene and covertly in other scenes of dilation as opening, publishing, and exposing an "occulted guilt," the sense of the secret faults of women combines with the play's striking preoccupation with spying, but also with what James Calderwood calls go-betweens as get-betweens, with delays, and with opacity.⁸⁴ Women in *Hamlet* are repeatedly associated with this interposed "between," as with the space of dilative and potentially threatening increase. Gertrude not only "comes between" Old Hamlet and his brother Claudius, as a "jointress" (I.ii.9) in several overdetermined senses; she also falls victim, finally, in an act of coming between or intercepting the poison Claudius means for Hamlet. Ophelia is "loosed" by Polonius as a means of policy (II.ii.162), part of the emphasis in the play on the interposing of women into affairs between men, in lines that lead directly to Polonius's "What is the matter?" and Hamlet's "Between who?" Players whose "show" and "tell" are linked with the female mouth and the privacy or *O* that O-phelia may be "ashamed to show" fail as messengers as well as secretories, unable not only to keep counsel but to bring (like Claudius's messengers to Norway) the hoped-for "end" (II.ii.85).

The multiple eyes of the *Mousetrap* scene, with its doubled onstage spectators, are, however, focused not just on this theatrical show but on a king who is himself both watcher and watched, spectator and anxious object of Hamlet's eye. In the context of the gender crossings that include the incestuous syllogism making Claudius into Hamlet's "mother" in Act IV (IV.iii.49–52), the scene of the play-within-a-play designed to "catch the conscience of the King" also elicits the "con-," *count*, or euphemistic "country matter" lurking within this monarchical "conscience" and its closeted secrets, in a *Mouse-trap* whose name will soon be echoed in the "Mouse," or pet name for Gertrude, in the closet scene.⁸⁵ Spying into the secrets or "occulted guilt" of a king who in the "union" of one flesh is both father and mother, is thus already, in the "shew" of dumb show and mouse trap, associated with the language of spying into a "privity," the secrets of the closeted and the hid. The fact that the cross-gendering performed by this collapsing syllogism also comes just after Hamlet's invocation (IV.iii.48) of the figure of spying and "intelligence" ("I see a cherub that sees them") further links this king's secret, occult, or hidden designs with the matter of a woman to be spied upon. And the lines in Act IV

that begin by invoking the two bodies of a king and move to "The King is a thing . . . / Of nothing" (IV.ii.28–30)—repeating the earlier rhyme of *king* and *thing* (II.ii.604–5)—explicitly assimilate the watched and watching king to the "o" or female nothing that was the focus in the *Mousetrap* scene of all its obscene play on "lap" and "show."

Though it is not activated in *Hamlet* in the same way as in *Othello*, such gender crossing or confusion was of course also part of the "secret" of an English transvestite theater, itself suggestive of more hidden from the eye than could be shown. In the antitheatrical literature that condemned such confusions themselves as monstrous, the very term of opprobrium evoked both the threat posed when outward signs failed to provide what Philip Stubbes termed a "signe distinctive" of the unseen and the polemicists' own obsession with making the hidden visible, as with the danger of falsification or forgery.⁸⁶ Here again was posed in this period—in yet another form—the problem of evidence raised so prominently in both plays. For the uncertainty of evidence and opacity to the rapacity of the eye extended on the English stage to the problem of exactly what was seen, in the transvestite context of a theater that frustrated even as it provoked desire for the revelation of a secret. The gender crossings, conflation, or confusions that associate Claudius's "conscience" and "occulted guilt" with the play around the dumb show on the nothing that "lies between maids' legs" also complicate what Ophelia (played by a boy actor) might be ashamed to show, part of the more general problem of evidence as what is contradictorily suggested to the eye's *invidia*.

In the context of a theater that at moments activated and at other moments dissimulated the open secret of female roles played by boys, what is at issue (as Peter Stallybrass has pointed out) was not so much an indeterminacy of gender as a superimposition or oscillation of gender expectations, in which a secret or hidden privy (or fault) could be alternately each place (or both).⁸⁷ Scenes like the one at the end of *Othello* where Desdemona (both female character and boy actor) undresses for bed—a scene that would seem to promise "ocular proof" of the "body beneath" the "signe distinctive"—produce instead an oscillation and radical instability of evidence, in a context in which the actor is simultaneously woman *and* boy and a play that itself exploits the sense of an "ensign" or "sign" that refuses to divulge what is beyond show.⁸⁸

Such shifting and contrary fixations, however, as Stallybrass argues, are precisely what also animate *Othello*, in passages like the one that de-

pend on the vivid *enargeia* of Iago's description of himself in bed with Cassio:

I lay with Cassio lately.

.....

In sleep I heard him say, "Sweet Desdemona,
Let us be wary, let us hide our loves";
And then, sir, would he gripe and wring my hand;
Cry, "O sweet creature!" then kiss me hard,
As if he pluck'd up kisses by the roots
That grew upon my lips; then laid his leg
Over my thigh, and sigh'd, and kiss'd.

(III.iii.414-25)

In a play that places such extraordinary emphasis on the occupying but also on the changing of place (the emphasis that gives such resonance elsewhere in this scene to the place "filled up" by Cassio himself as lieutenant), such a passage is dizzying in its blurring of places and roles—Cassio addressing Iago as Desdemona, in a theater where Desdemona herself was played not by an actress but by a boy. The oscillation releases into the play, if only subtly and momentarily, the ambiguity and evidential uncertainty of the place or "lieu" itself, the very place that is the obsessive focus of the desire to bring forth to show.

Antitheatrical writers had, of course, their own obsession with the visible, as with secret faults or crimes associated with sexual secrets and unsanctioned couplings. And it was the ambiguities evoked by the theater's transvestism that activated the contrary fixations of their own obsession with making the hidden visible:

O . . . that thou couldest in that sublime watch-tower insinuate thine eyes into these Players secrets; or set open the closed dores of their bed-chambers, and bring all their innermost hidden Cels unto the conscience of thine eyes. . . . Men rush on men with outrageous lusts.⁸⁹

This is the sense of the secrets behind theatrical show that Phillip Stubbes denounced: "these goodly pageants being done, every mate sorts to his mate . . . and in their secret conclaves (*covertly*) they play the Sodomits, or worse."⁹⁰ It reminds us that the public theater—attended in record numbers by citizen wives as well as "common" women (the term that resonates in Othello's "O thou public *commoner*")—was a locus not only of female enfranchisement and display, beyond the surveillance of father

or husband, but also of homosexual prostitution and the "secret" of sodomy.



Friends all, but now, even now,
In quarter, and in terms like bride and groom
Devesting them for bed.

Othello

In relation to the exchanges of place so prominent in *Othello*, the Moor comes in one respect to occupy the perspective of a proprietary Venetian husband, concerned with the occupation of his wife. But he also becomes the more passive receiver of another's informing, his ear "pierced" (I.iii. 219), "abuse[d]" (395), or—in a different metaphoricity—"colonized" by that informer, his "occupation" gone as he himself is "occupied," in a process again described as bringing a "monstrous birth" to light (404).⁹¹ This other coupling complicates the heterosexual erotics of the play with all of its insistent homoerotic imagery, climaxing in the parody-marriage of Iago and Othello in Act III and adding to the already multiple senses of informing that of the monstrous shaping or giving form that comes of this displaced insemination and conception. It thereby adds to the play's fantasies of heterosexual racial mixing (the coupling of white Desdemona and "lascivious" Moor) the complications of a monstrous union of Iago and the Moor—a relation in which this Moor is by implication sexually "fallowed" ("as asses are," I.iii.402) rather than loyally "follow[ed]" by his Venetian subordinate (I.i.58), a reversal of their hierarchical relationship into a form of "service" frequently associated with exoticized others in the period of the play.⁹²

Iago "abuses" the ear of a Moor of "Barbary," a form of penetration that leads (with Desdemona excluded) to the "monstrous birth" that becomes the only progeny of the fantasies of such mixing that haunt this play from its beginning, starting with Iago's vivid imagining of all that is to ensue from the adulterating of "kind" ("your daughter cover'd with a Barbary horse, you'll have your nephews neigh to you . . . coursers for cousins, and gennets for Germans," I.i.111–13). The monstrous in this play—as in its culture—includes the *abusio* of homoerotic practices as yet another barbarous form of "sin against kinde," the coupling that in the charged *enargeia* of Cassio embracing Iago in bed (III.iii.413–426) produces Othello's "O monstrous! monstrous!" (427), glancing as it passes at the term for the monstrous abuses of an English theater in which the

secret of Desdemona included the fact that she was acted by a boy. It also evokes the very term that characterized denunciations of this other monstrous sexual practice, projected onto non-European or non-English others (including Iberians and inhabitants of "Barbary") as yet another familiar staple of "travellours histories."

I put this pressure, finally, on more of what was included within the early modern designation of the monstrous because we have to do, both in *Othello* and in its culture, with the violence of projection itself, propelled by the uneasy sense of "occupation" that comes from the blurring of boundaries between alien and civil, outside and an inside already occupied by "adulterating" mixtures.⁹³ *Othello* provides us not only with this violence, and its chiasmic splittings, displayed and summoned forth to show, but with the ostensible oxymoron of the "civil monster" (IV.i.64)—a phrase that, detached from its immediate context, might be applied to the Venetian/Iberian figure of Iago, but which in more pervasive and unsettling ways also exposes the contradictions at the heart of the civil or civilized itself. It is this only apparent oxymoron from *Othello* that best conveys the sense in the play, or more largely within early modern culture, of the projected other as both mirror and split chiasmic counterpart of the monstrous at home, a home already "occupied" and hence unsettlingly incapable of fortification against invasion. Within the realm of the visual, it also names that particular form of crossing and othering in which what is brought to light is at the same time that which cannot—or *must* not—be seen.

We began with the close or secret in the context of the hidden fault or privy of women, in relation to the obsession in both *Hamlet* and *Othello* with what is hidden or unseen. But the transvestite theatrical context of these plays, creating its own problem of evidence, of more hidden from the eye than is shown, extends the problem of secrets and their visibility to the "open secret" of another crime or fault, one also described in the language of the secret, the monstrous, and the hid. Simonds D'Ewes wrote of Francis Bacon that he would not "relinquish the practice of his *most horrible and secret sin of sodomy*," linking this "*unnatural crime* which he had practised many years" to the customs of "italians and turks," in yet another projection of a domestic "secret sin" onto the culturally alien or remote. Alan Bray comments on the symptomatic inconsistency here between the description of Bacon's "secret" sin and the fact that others (including the author) were aware of it. And this open secret extended to James I, who could denounce sodomy as among unforgivable "crimes"

(*Basilikon Doron*) and at the same time write of his "marriage" to his "sweet child and wife" as well as "dear dad and husband" in a letter to George Villiers.⁹⁴

Sodomy as the unspeakable crime or fault—itsself associated with closets, secret chambers, and privy spaces—was, as recent work has demonstrated, an integral part of the history of private life in the period. D'Ewes reports on private conversation of "things . . . that weere secrett as of the sinne of sodomye" and of "how frequente it was in this wicked cittye, . . . especially it being as wee had probable cause to feare, a sinne in the prince as well as the people."⁹⁵ Part of the intimacy associated with these closets and inner chambers, as David Starkey has argued, had to do with the rise of the Privy Chamber in particular as a locus of political power based on physical proximity to the king, a chamber originally associated with another kind of privy. Jonathan Goldberg has identified one such intimate of a king in the brother of Anne Boleyn, and a triangle that suggests once again the indeterminacy and ambiguity of a "lieu" that defies more determinate modern boundaries; while the drama contemporary with Shakespeare makes clear that there were homo- as well as heterosexual contexts in which a privy could be open, dilated, or spread.⁹⁶



All of what was designated by the monstrous, the secret, and the privy, finally—activated in different ways by the preoccupations of *Othello* or *Hamlet*—links the political and the sexual in ways that are not susceptible to more modern boundaries or divisions. In the case of *Hamlet*, what emerges in its buried linkages involves not so much what is embodied in the characters of Gertrude and Ophelia as something independent of embodiment, the link between obsession with female shew and the play's obsession with secrets, spying, and intelligence, in a play staged late in the reign of a queen who emphasized her own tantalizing gender uncertainty—father and mother to her people, "frail" body of a woman and body of a king—as well as the controlled display but finally the opacity of her closet, privy chamber, and her "secretes."⁹⁷ In the famous Rainbow Portrait of this same queen, a portrait whose sexual inference is invoked by the placing of an ear (another organ folded or lapped) over the locus of her "secrete" part, the political implications of surveillance cannot be separated from the sexualized reading of its proliferating eyes and ears. James I had his own obsession with the secretive, not just in his exaggerated regard for secret texts but in the secrecy surrounding what became

the open secret of his own succession.⁹⁸ What is important in eliciting from *Hamlet* or *Othello* their complex evocations of spying, informing, and exposing secrets in a context that also involves fascination with a hidden sexual privity is the way the private in this sense crosses with the political in early modern England, linking the language of the plays and the discourses—anatomical, medical, theatrical, judicial—of the culture that forms the broader context for their demand to see and know.

When Elizabeth delivered her famous pronouncement on the spectacle of monarchy—"We princes are set on stages in the sight and view of the world"—or when James warned his son that kings are placed on a stage "where all the beholders' eyes are attentively bent to look and pry into the least circumstances of their secretest drifts,"⁹⁹ both were addressing the circumstances of an England that included not only an increasingly elaborated secret service as the dispersed eyes and ears of state but also increasingly extended networks of mediation and representation, of secretories and go-betweens that simultaneously conveyed and enfolded messages and "secretes," as well as not infrequently interposing their own will between. It was also—in striking relation to both monarchs—an England that had recourse to the language of a chamber, closeting, or secrets as a complexly deflected (or, as in *Hamlet*, "troping") cover for the simultaneously hidden and open secret of a homosexuality tied selectively to the visibility, culpability, and detection of other "monstrous" things. This too, along with a homoerotics of the desire to see and know, the self-consciously theatrical theater of Shakespeare—its "show" and "tell"—folds into its metaphors of spying, of showing, and of opacity or withholding from vision.

Far, then, from perpetuating an earlier agenda of close reading that separated Shakespeare artificially from this history (and that, ironically, often resulted in an inability to read even the most fundamental verbal resonances of the plays) and far from abandoning careful reading altogether in reaction to that formal bracketing, we need to attend to the characteristic terms not only of the plays but of the culture contemporary with them. Striking examples of such simultaneously textual and contextual study have already been initiated, no longer attached to simply formalist or politically more conservative aims. My own argument starts in part from the premise that apparently minor elements like the "close dilations" of *Othello*, the wordplay around the dumb show in *Hamlet*, or the "delations" of Claudius's scripting of his messenger/ambassadors, operate—like the other instances treated here—in ways less easily accessible

to the anachronistic assumptions of logical, psychological or chronological plausibility on which so much critical energy has been spent. But it also starts, in this exploration as throughout the study it concludes, from the conviction that the plays of Shakespeare—like other early modern texts—offer us terms that if read historically would provide clues to the language of the culture they complexly demonstrate or hold up to show. To approach a culture as important to and yet distant from us as that now termed the early modern must be to take its own complexly developing language seriously. To read with care in this sense is not simply to add to the resources of cultural studies or cultural poetics those of a cultural semantics or philology; but to begin to explore the network of terms that shaped politics, institutions, and laws, as well as discourses of the body and all that we have subsequently come to think of as literature.